

▼ ICE CAVE

Meltwater can carve spectacular ice caves beneath glaciers.

Glaciers and ice sheets

In cold climates, snowfall may not melt, even in summer. It builds up in layers that turn into ice, forming glaciers. These flow slowly downhill until they either melt or reach the sea. In polar regions, huge glaciers form thick ice sheets that smother the landscape and even extend over the ocean as ice shelves.

CREEPING GLACIERS

Ice made from compacted snow in the mountains builds up and creeps downhill as glaciers. The moving ice carves away the landscape, creating deep U-shaped valleys. It also carries rock debris away in long heaps of rubble on the glacier edges, or in the middle where two glaciers have joined. These are called moraines.

SNOW TO ICE

High in the mountains, some of the snow that falls in winter stays frozen throughout the summer. When winter sets in again, more snow falls on top of it. Over time, the snow builds up. Its weight compresses the lower layers, expelling most of the air and turning the snow into solid blue ice.

